

Internal Communication and Information Architecture: How Organizations Coordinate

Executive Summary

Communication is the nervous system of the organization. Under Active Inference, communication is how **different agents within the organization share and align their generative models** — exchanging signals that enable coordinated action. This module examines how information architecture shapes organizational cognition, why communication failures are fundamentally failures of model alignment, and how to design communication systems that reduce organizational free energy.

Learning Objectives

1. Understand organizational communication as **model alignment** — sharing beliefs and predictions across agents
 2. Analyze **information architecture**: reporting structures, meeting cadences, and data flows
 3. Identify communication failures as **model misalignment** between organizational subunits
 4. Apply the concept of **common ground** as shared priors that enable coordination
 5. Design communication systems that reduce organizational prediction error
-

Key Concepts

1. Communication as Model Sharing

When teams communicate effectively, they are aligning their **generative models**: ensuring that everyone has compatible beliefs about the environment, consistent goals, and coordinated action plans.

Communication Function	Active Inference Translation	Example
Reporting results	Sharing sensory evidence with other agents	Monthly sales report
Setting objectives	Aligning preferred states across agents	Annual goal-setting cascade
Giving context	Updating another agent's priors	Briefing a new team member
Requesting feedback	Seeking to reduce uncertainty about one's own model	"How did the client receive our proposal?"
Escalating issues	Signaling high prediction error to higher-level agents	"We're 20% behind target — need leadership input"

2. Information Architecture

The structural design of how information flows through the organization:

Formal channels: Org chart, reporting lines, meeting structures, dashboards **Informal channels:** Water-cooler conversations, Slack channels, lunch meetings, mentorship

Case Study — Spotify's Squad Model: Spotify designed an information architecture with "squads" (autonomous teams), "tribes" (groups of squads in the same area), "chapters" (functional specialists across squads), and "guilds" (communities of interest). This matrix structure creates multiple channels for model alignment — squads align on product direction, chapters align on technical practices, and guilds align on cross-cutting concerns. The design explicitly addresses the model-sharing problem at multiple scales.

3. Common Ground: Shared Priors for Coordination

Effective communication requires **common ground** — shared assumptions that don't need to be re-established every time agents interact:

- **Shared language:** Common terminology (enabled by the glossary in this curriculum)
- **Shared context:** Understanding of the business situation
- **Shared goals:** Alignment on what "success" means
- **Shared norms:** Agreement on how to collaborate

When common ground is absent, communication becomes expensive: every message requires extensive context-setting, misunderstandings multiply, and coordination costs dominate.

4. Communication Failures as Model Misalignment

Failure	Symptom	Active Inference Diagnosis
Silo mentality	Departments don't share information	Agents maintain local models without cross-boundary communication
Information hoarding	Individuals withhold information	Agents treat information as a private resource rather than a shared model component
Mixed messages	Different leaders say different things	Multiple high-level agents broadcasting conflicting model updates
Communication overload	Too many meetings, too many emails	Excessive model-alignment attempts → no capacity left for actual inference and action
Lost in translation	Technical teams and executives talk past each other	Different generative models (specialist vs. generalist) with insufficient common ground

5. Designing Effective Communication Systems

Principles for organizational communication architecture:

1. **Match communication cadence to decision cadence:** Daily standups for daily operations, quarterly reviews for strategic decisions
 2. **Create bidirectional channels:** Not just top-down broadcasting — enable bottom-up signal propagation
 3. **Build common ground deliberately:** Shared dashboards, regular cross-functional meetings, rotational programs
 4. **Reduce unnecessary communication:** Not all agents need all information — filter based on relevance
 5. **Use boundary objects:** Artifacts (documents, prototypes, metrics) that bridge different specialist models
-

Applications

Communication Audit

Map how information flows in your organization:

- What are the formal reporting channels?
 - Where does information get stuck or distorted?
 - Which teams have the strongest common ground? The weakest?
 - Is communication cadence matched to decision cadence?
-

Cross-References

- For cross-team alignment and model sharing, see [Collective Intelligence: Communication](#)
- For stakeholder communication and narrative strategy, see [Strategic Modeling: Communication](#)

- For API integration and system interoperability, see [Digital Transformation: Communication](#)
-

Summary

Concept	Organizational Meaning
Communication	Sharing and aligning generative models across agents
Information architecture	The structural design of information flows
Common ground	Shared priors that reduce coordination costs
Model misalignment	Communication failures where agents have incompatible beliefs
Boundary objects	Artifacts that bridge specialist model differences

References

- Nonaka, I., & Takeuchi, H. (1995). *The Knowledge-Creating Company*. Oxford University Press.
- Weick, K. E. (1995). *Sensemaking in Organizations*. Sage.
- Veissière, S. P. L., et al. (2020). Thinking through other minds. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 43, e90.